

Summary: Iwamoto, "The Development of Japanese Forestry"

Source: Junichi Iwamoto, book chapter (9 pp.), undated (references to 2000-2001 data; published early 2000s). Companion piece to Totman's *The Green Archipelago*.

Core argument

Japan's plantation forestry emerged in three waves, each driven by urban demand rather than resource abundance: (1) late 17th century, as Edo and Osaka boomed under the Tokugawa Shogunate; (2) early 20th century, industrial growth plus post-war (Sino-Japanese, Russo-Japanese) reconstruction demand; (3) 1950s-60s, postwar/Korean War economic recovery — the largest boom, peaking 1955-1970.

Key points

- **Tenure systems (Tokugawa era, 1603-1867):** land was either feudal-lord tenure or communal (commons) tenure — individual ownership was banned in principle. Feudal-lord forests (e.g., Kiso) were tightly guarded, with theft severely punished.
- **Kiso case study:** first reform (1665) cut timber production by half via seedling protection/patrols/selective cutting, but was reversed within years for revenue. A second reform (1724) cut production >60% and succeeded — 30 years of restraint let the forest recover. Forest inventory/planning began there in 1779, an early example of sustained-yield thinking.
- **Commons plantation forestry (Yoshino, Owase):** from the late 17th–18th century, farmers began planting sugi/hinoki on communal land, encouraged by local custom recognizing *private ownership of individually planted trees* even on communal land — a key institutional innovation that made investment in slow-growing timber rational. Owase (a port town) saw wealthy merchants finance larger plantations using local labor; Yoshino developed an early market for young (20-30yr) standing timber, letting farmers sell before maturity.
- **Drivers of urbanization → deforestation → plantation:** Edo reached ~1,000,000 people by 1801 (larger than London or Paris), driving huge timber demand for construction, worsened by frequent city fires. The Tokugawa isolationist policy blocked timber imports, forcing domestic supply pressure that pushed plantation forestry.
- **Meiji era (1868 on):** formal land ownership introduced; national forests created from communal + former feudal land. 1899-1915: 16-year project surveyed and classified forests into "necessary"/"unnecessary," selling the latter to fund management of the former. First Forest Law (1897, regulation-focused) → Second Forest Law (1907, shifted to utilization) as industrial growth demanded efficient production.
- **20th-century communal forest shift:** from subsistence use (fuelwood, manure) to state-promoted afforestation, linked to funding the Sino-Japanese and Russo-Japanese wars via rural sacrifice.
- **Post-WWII boom and its collapse:** artificial planting peaked 1955, stayed high to 1970, then fell sharply (Fig. 1.2) as imported timber undercut Japanese wood on cost (rising domestic wages) — self-sufficiency fell from ~95% (1955) to ~20% (2000) (Fig. 1.3), a monotonic multi-decade decline.
- **Present-day problem (as of ~2000):** most postwar plantations are now unmanaged/undermanaged

due to low profitability and forestry labor shortage. Growing recognition of forests' environmental value (erosion control, water, biodiversity) exists, but Japan lags other industrialized countries in the shift to "environmentally oriented new forestry."

Relevance to Mitsue project

Directly supports [[project_reforestation_principle]] and [[project_forest_workforce_energy_plan]]: the historical pattern — plant under urban demand pressure, then abandon when uneconomic — is exactly the cycle Mitsue's Sugi/Hinoki plantations are now in. The Yoshino/Owase institutional lesson (recognizing individual ownership of planted trees on communal land to incentivize long-horizon investment) may be a useful precedent when structuring any forest-worker or NGO replanting incentive scheme. Also gives concrete historical grounding for outreach/deck narrative about "three planting booms and now the fourth crisis."